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76-107: Writing About Data

Comparing Persuasion in Political Interviews and Speeches

Abstract

Politicians attempt to persuade constituents through, among other ways, speeches and interviews. However, there is a gap of research into the differences in persuasion between speeches and interviews. This study compared the persuasion in these two media. We measured the usage of hedge, emotional, and booster words in a corpus of 15 political speeches and a corpus of 15 political interviews using concordance software. Results showed that political interviews used more hedge words and booster words, but both used a similar amount of emotional words, demonstrating stronger persuasion in political interviews. Further studies should be conducted using larger corpora and more discerning word counting to better understand the persuasion between the two media.

Introduction

Being public servants of the most prominent kind, politicians must connect and communicate with their constituents. Politicians are also typically trying to persuade people of something. Two ways of doing so are speeches and interviews. While there is research on the methods of persuasion used by politicians, there is currently little on the difference in persuasion between their speeches and their interviews. The purpose of this study is to fill this gap by analyzing speeches and interviews of politicians in order to understand the differences in persuasion between the two situations. Ultimately, we

intend to answer the question: How do politicians' speeches and interviews compare in terms of persuasion?

Methods

To investigate persuasion, we analyzed two different corpora, one of speeches by politicians, and one of interviews with politicians.

Corpus Selection

The corpus of speeches by politicians contained a variety of speeches from American politicians, such as John F. Kennedy, Alejandro Padilla, and Rachel Levine. It comprised 15 texts from 1966-2022 taken from a variety of archives and websites. The corpus contained 33,335 words total, an average of 2,222.3 words per speech. The corpus of interviews contained a similar variety, including interviews with Andy Kim and Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez. It too contained 15 texts and was taken from a variety of archives and websites. The interviews occurred between 2007 and 2022 and contained a total of 46,515 words, an average of 3,101 words per interview.

Procedures

We used three variables to compare persuasion between the corpora: hedge words, emotional words, and booster words.

Hedge Words

Hedge words indicate an uncertainty from the speaker and an unwillingness to fully commit to an idea. Common hedge words include "maybe," "potentially," and "possibly" (see Appendix A). We used a list of hedge words provided by Birkbeck, University of London (Birkbeck). A higher usage of hedge words implies less effective

persuasion in a text, as the speaker appears less sure of themselves, and so the audience is less inclined to believe them.

Emotional Words

Unlike hedge words, emotional words are a formal mode of persuasion. They reveal the usage of pathos in a text, an attempt to strengthen an argument by evoking emotion within the audience. These words include “hopeless,” “loved,” and “outraged” (see Appendix B). The list of emotional words is provided by “Overcoming Depression: Thoughts and Depression” (Gilson). An increase in the usage of emotional words correlates to more effective persuasion, as the audience is more connected to the speaker, and then more inclined to believe their message.

Booster Words

On the opposite side to hedge words, speakers use booster words to deliberately aggrandize their argument and make it seem stronger. These words are commonly not essential to the central message; some common booster words are “extremely,” “conclusively,” and “particularly” (see Appendix C). Increased usage of booster words imply an increase in effectiveness of argument, as they emphasize the speaker’s side of the argument and make it seem more valid.

Measurements

To measure each variable, we used the concordance software AntConc (Anthony, 2020). The advanced search feature was used to search for uses of the words (see appendices), and the count for each variable was normed to 1,000 words.

Results

Overall, the results point to a higher level of persuasion in political interviews. Persuasion in each corpus was measured using the usage of hedge words, emotional words, and booster words. While emotional words were used approximately the same amount, interviews used more hedge and booster words per 1,000 words.

Hedge Words

Political interviews used more hedge words than political speeches. Figure 1 shows that political interviews corpus included 13.15 hedge words per 1,000 words, while the corpus of political speeches used 7.15 per 1,000 words. This is a difference of 6 hedge words used per 1,000 words.

Political interviews used the verb “think,” and related constructions, much more heavily than political speeches. These include “think that” and “think it;” constructions using “think” compose six of the top ten most used hedge words in political interviews. Additionally, political interviews used the same few hedge words much more frequently. The most used hedge word in speeches, “believe that,” was used 0.35 times per 1,000 words, while the most used hedge in interviews, “think that,” was spoken 0.96 times per 1,000 words. Here included is an example sentence from a political interview, with hedges highlighted.

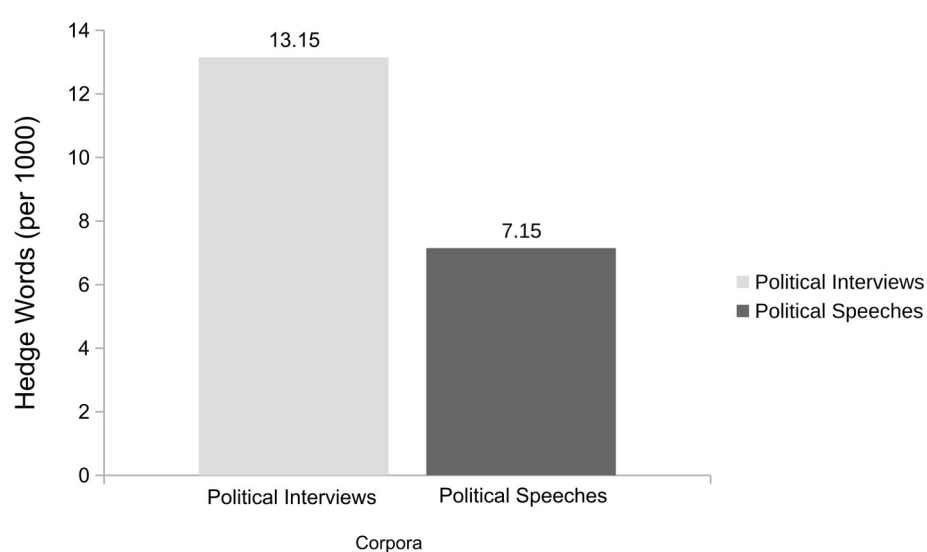


Figure 1: Hedge words used per 1,000 words in political speeches and Political Interviews.

“I guess the answer **would** be that you **could** avoid a particular negative narrative. Right, and I **believe** that the narratives exist because...” — (IP Illhan Omar)

Here is a sample from a political speech.

“Anyone who **believes** that words are not the same as actions, who believe that LGBTQI+ people **should** just toughen up, **should** walk a mile in our shoes.”
— (PS Levine)

Emotional Words

Unlike hedge words, political speeches and interviews used roughly similar amounts of emotional words. Figure 2 shows that the political interview corpus incorporated 8.45 emotional words per 1,000 words, and the political speech corpus included 9.74. These two values have a difference of 1.29 words per 1,000 words.

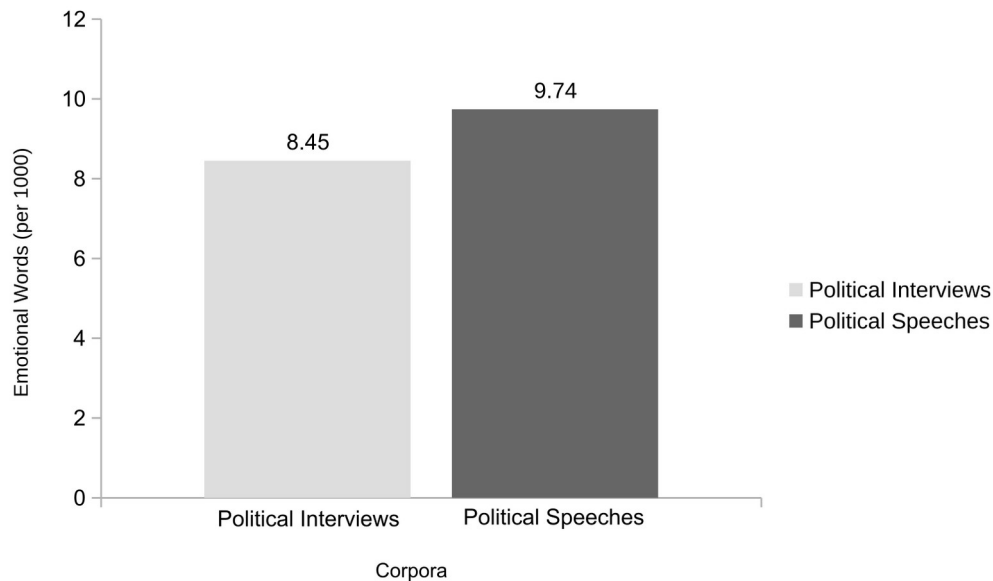


Figure 2: Emotional words used per 1,000 words in political speeches and interviews.

Although they had similar overall amounts of emotional words, the two corpora used different types of emotional word. Political interviews commonly used emotional words indicating personal belief, chiefly “sure that,” “important for,” and “concerned about.” Meanwhile, political speeches’ emotional words typically related more to international affairs and events; some of the speeches’ most used emotional words include “forced to,” “Cold War,” and “threatened by.” Included is a sample sentence from a political interview including emotional words, which are highlighted.

“For example, it’s a lot easier for a politician to say, “Police **good**; rioting **bad**” than it is to say...” — (IP Illhan Omar)

Here is a similar sample from a political speech.

“To our sister republics south of our border, we offer a special pledge—to convert our **good** words into **good** deeds—in a new alliance for progress—to assist **free**

men and **free** governments in casting off the chains of poverty.” — (PS Kennedy).

Booster Words

More similar to hedge words, political interviews used many more booster words than political speeches. Per Figure 3, the political interview corpus included 11.27 booster words per 1,000 words, and the political speech corpus had 5.65 booster words per 1,000 words. This is a difference of 5.62 booster words per 1,000 words; that is, political interviews use almost double the booster words as political speeches.

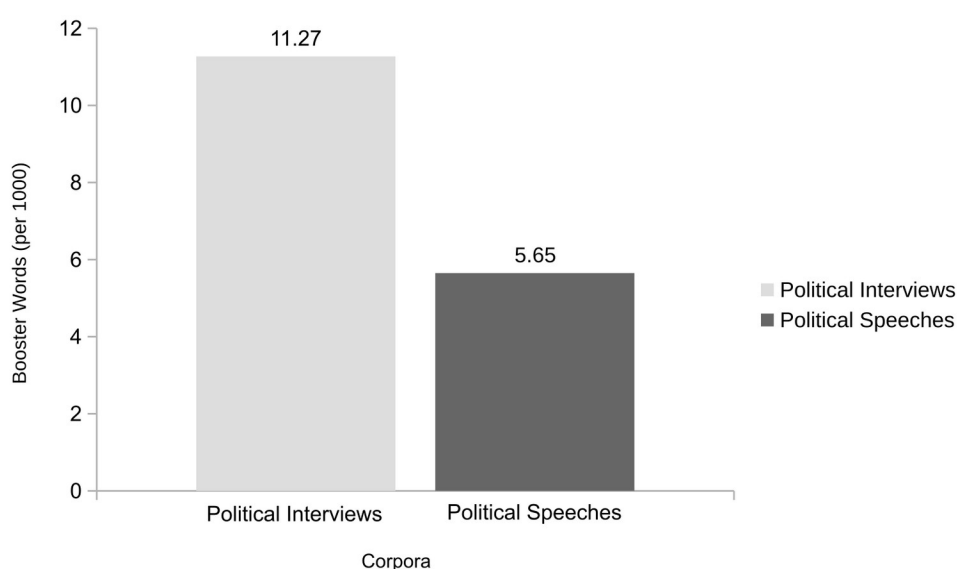


Fig 3: Booster words used per 1,000 words in political speeches and political interviews.

The skew of the distribution of booster word usage per political interview is further left than the skew of the distribution in political speeches. That is, the usage of booster words in political speeches is clumped more at higher values, with a tail of values extending lower. For political interviews, the distribution between the individual

articles was more evenly spread between high and low values. The corpus of political speeches had a skewness of -0.67, while the political interview corpus has a skewness of -0.21, a difference of 0.46. Here is an example of a sentence from the political interview corpus, with booster words highlighted.

“I think that, you **know**, I **actually** wrote a book many years ago, and I do believe that it is **important** for us to have a cyber doctrine.” — (IP Kamala Harris).

Here is a corresponding excerpt from a political speech.

“**Clearly**, Saddam Hussein has not been an agent of progress. And **clearly**, what is now need not **always** be.” — (PS Albright).

Discussion

This study compared the levels of persuasion in political speeches and interviews. To do so, the variables of normed count of hedge words, emotional words, and booster words were used. Those results revealed that hedge words and booster words are used more in political interviews and that emotional words are used approximately the same in both media.

The data show that political interviews used, on average, many more hedge words per 1,000 words. One potential reason for this is that politicians during interviews are speaking on-the-spot, while speeches are prepared and reviewed beforehand. Thus, an interviewed politician would not want to lay down a hastily-prepared thought as fact, as they risk political blowback should such a claim be false. Hedge words serve as a cushion against this chance. Meanwhile, speeches are laid out well prior to their delivery, allowing for close scrutiny of their claims. They would therefore likely fewer

hedge words to protect against adverse statements, as they can remove those statements before they happen. In both situations, however, hedge words are ultimately used.

Unlike hedge words, emotional words directly affect the persuasion in that they serve to connect the speaker to the audience and to better persuade them. In both interviews and speeches, the politician looks to convince the audience of some point; that intention would benefit from a closer connection between speaker and audience, as is provided by emotional words. This may explain why emotional words are used a similar amount in both situations.

A possible reason that political interviews incorporate more booster words than speeches could be similar to that of hedge words. Booster words make an argument seem stronger and more definite while actually providing no substance. In an on-the-spot interview, it is easier for a politician to add booster words to their response to make it seem stronger than it is to think up a more substantive answer. On the other hand, speeches and their messages are planned long in advance, so there is less of a need for booster words to make up that difference. Nevertheless, booster words do make any argument appear stronger, so both interviews and speeches do use them.

This study had several limitations, one of which is the lack of full representation in the corpora. Both corpora included only text from major, federal politicians, completely ignoring state and local politicians. While the corpus of speeches did include select bureaucrats such as Rachel Levine, the corpus of interviews comprised entirely members of the US. Congress and of the Presidency or Vice Presidency. This selection

was far from representative of the set of all political speeches. Additionally, the search feature of AntConc failed to account for the context of each word. For example, the word “central” may serve as a booster word, for example in the phrase “this is central to our plan;” however it may also merely be an adjective, as in “Central America.” AntConc did not account for these possibilities, and so may have miscalculated the true usage of the three variables.

Future studies could improve upon this one by using larger corpora accounting for more politicians over a wider time period. Additionally, incorporating more nuanced methods to detect usage of specific types of words could provide more definite and generalized results.

Works Cited

Anthony, L. (2020). AntConc (Version 3.5.9) [Computer Software]. Tokyo, Japan:

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Gilson, Freedman, et al. Overcoming Depression: Thoughts and Depression: The T of the BEAST. Copyright © 2009 by Oxford University Press

Appendix A: Hedge Word List

May, might, could, would, should, seem, appear, believe, assume, suggest, estimate, tend, think, argue, propose, speculate, possible, probable, unlikely, likely, assumption, claim, possibility, estimate, suggestion, perhaps, possibly, probably, practically, likely, presumably, virtually, apparently, approximately, roughly, often, occasionally, generally, usually, somewhat, somehow, feel, maybe, unsure

Appendix B: Emotional Word List

Jubilant, grievous, irritated, shocked, unsettled, justified, helpless, mad, shy, unsure, loved, hopeless, offended, skeptical, marvelous, humbled, outraged, startled, optimistic, inadequate, patronized, stunned, peaceful, islanded, peeved, suspicious, pleased, isolated, perturbed, swamped, proud, lonely, pissed, off, tense, relaxed, miserable, provoked, terrified, relieved, mournful, rebellious, threatened, resolved, neglected, repulsed, timid, respected, pitiful, resentful, tormented, satisfied, regretful, ridiculed, uneasy, terrific, rejected, sabotaged, unsure, thrilled, resigned, seething, vulnerable, tranquil, sorrowful, smothered, valued, terrible, spiteful, unappreciated, stifled, uncared, strangled, unloved, throttled, unwanted, uptight, upset, used, worthless, vengeful, wounded, vindictive, admired, alienated, abused, afraid, ambivalent, alive, ashamed, aggravated, alarmed, awkward, appreciated, burdened, agitated, anxious, baffled, assured, condemned, anguished, appalled, bewildered, cheerful, crushed, annoyed, apprehensive, bothered, confident, defeated, betrayed, awed, constricted, content, dejected, cheated, concerned, directionless, delighted, demoralized, coerced, defensive, disorganized, determined, depressed, controlled, desperate, distracted, ecstatic, deserted, deceived, doubtful, elated, despised, disgusted, fearful, flustered, encouraged, devastated, dismayed, frantic, foggy, energized, disappointed, displeased, dread, hesitant, enthusiastic, discarded, dominated, guarded, immobilized, excited, discouraged, enraged, horrified, misunderstood, exuberant, disgraced, exasperated, impatient, perplexed, flattered, disheartened, exploited, insecure, puzzled, fortunate, disillusioned, frustrated, intimidated, stagnant, fulfilled, dismal, fuming, nervous, surprised, glad, distant, furious, overwhelmed, torn, good, distraught, harassed, panicky, trapped, grateful, distressed, hateful, perplexed, troubled, gratified, drained, hostile, petrified, uncertain, hopeful, empty, humiliated, reluctant, uncomfortable, joyful, exhausted, incensed, shaken, undecided, insensitive, fearful, crushed, tearful, dull, terrified, tormented, sorrowful, nonchalant, suspicious, deprived, pained, neutral, anxious, pained, grief, reserved, alarmed, tortured, anguish, weary, panic, dejected, desolate, bored, nervous, rejected, desperate, preoccupied, scared, injured, pessimistic, cold, worried, offended, unhappy, disinterested, frightened, afflicted, lonely, lifeless, timid, aching, grieved, shaky, victimized, mournful, restless, heartbroken, dismayed, doubtful, agonized, threatened, appalled, cowardly, humiliated, quaking, wronged, menaced, alienated, wary, irritated, lousy, upset, incapable, enraged, disappointed, doubtful, alone, hostile, discouraged, uncertain, paralyzed, insulting, ashamed, indecisive, fatigued, sore, powerless, perplexed, useless, annoyed, diminished, embarrassed, inferior, upset, guilty, hesitant, vulnerable, hateful, dissatisfied, shy, empty, unpleasant, miserable, stupefied, forced, offensive, detestable, disillusioned, hesitant, bitter, repugnant, unbelieving, despair, aggressive, despicable, skeptical, frustrated, resentful, disgusting, distrustful, distressed, inflamed, abominable, misgiving, woeful, provoked, terrible, lost, pathetic, incensed, in despair, unsure, tragic, infuriated, sulky, uneasy, in a stew, cross, bad, pessimistic, dominated, worked up, tense, boiling, fuming, indignant, understanding, great, playful, calm, confident, gay, courageous, peaceful, reliable, joyous, energetic, at ease, easy, lucky, liberated, comfortable, amazed, fortunate, optimistic, pleased, free, delighted, provocative, encouraged, sympathetic, overjoyed, impulsive, clever, interested, gleeful, free, surprised, satisfied, thankful, frisky, content, receptive, important, animated, quiet, accepting, festive, spirited, ecstatic, thrilled, relaxed, satisfied, wonderful, serene, glad, free and easy, cheerful, bright, sunny, blessed, merry, reassured, elated, jubilant, loving, concerned, eager, impulsive, considerate, affected, keen, free, affectionate, fascinated, earnest, sure, sensitive, intrigued, intent, certain, tender, absorbed, anxious, rebellious, devoted, inquisitive, inspired, unique, attracted, nosy, determined, dynamic, passionate, snoop, excited, tenacious, admiration, engrossed, enthusiastic, hardy, warm, curious, bold, secure, touched, brave, sympathy, daring, close, challenged, loved, optimistic, comforted, re-enforced, confident, hopeful

Appendix C: Booster Word List

Certain, certainly, definite, definitely, clear, clearly, undoubtably, obviously, substantially, always, very, extremely, indeed, undoubtedly, actually, know, prove, conclusively, sufficient, ample, extensive, evidently, critical, essential, central, particularly, important, rigorous, large